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Tonneau cover

Abstract

A pickup truck having a tonneau cover is provided. The tonneau cover includes a first panel section pivotable with respect to the opposing first and second upward-extending side walls. A first latching assembly is attached to the first panel section and is configured to selectively secure and release the first panel section with respect to the first and second side walls of the pickup truck. The first latching assembly includes first and second pinch latch assemblies. The first pinch latch assembly is located adjacent the first upward-extending side wall of the pickup truck and the second pinch latch assembly is located adjacent the second upward-extending side wall of the pickup truck.

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Background/Summary

RELATED APPLICATIONS (1) The present Application is a Continuation of application Ser. No. 16/933,069, filed on Jul. 20, 2020, entitled “Tonneau Cover,” which is a Continuation of application Ser. No. 16/101,900, filed on Aug. 13, 2018, entitled “Tonneau Cover,” now U.S. Pat. No. 10,717,350, which is a continuation of application Ser. No. 15/342,407, filed on Nov. 3, 2016, entitled “Tonneau Cover,” now U.S. Pat. No. 10,046,632, which claims priority to U.S. Provisional Patent Application, Ser. No. 62/250,649, filed on Nov. 4, 2015, entitled “Tonneau Cover.” The subject matter disclosed in those applications are hereby expressly incorporated into the present application by reference.

TECHNICAL FIELD AND SUMMARY

(1) The present disclosure relates to trucks such as pickup trucks, and truck beds used on pickup trucks and like vehicles, and, in particular, a truck bed cover also known as a tonneau cover that includes new features and is used on such truck beds.

(2) Tonneau covers are truck bed covers that provide a covering for a truck bed when used in combination with the truck's side walls and tailgate. Covering the bed of a pickup truck helps create a secure compartment where items may be stored out of view when the tailgate is up. Embodiments of a tonneau cover, according to the present disclosure, may provide any one or more of the following features: latch and pinch handle; vertical support assembly; a buckle system; a hinge seal spacer; seal rods; and side rails.

(3) An illustrative embodiment of the present disclosure provides a pickup truck that includes a bed section rear of a cab section. The bed section is bounded on each side by opposing first and second upward-extending side walls, respectively. The pickup truck includes a tonneau cover which comprises a base panel, a plurality of panel sections, a first latching assembly, and a second latching assembly. The base panel attaches to the opposing first and second upward-extending side walls and extends over the bed section of the pickup truck. The plurality of panel sections are each selectively movable to allow access to the bed section of the pickup truck. A first panel section of

the plurality of panel sections is pivotally attachable to the base panel. The first latching assembly is attached to the first panel section of the plurality of panel sections, and is configured to selectively secure and release the first panel section of the plurality of panel sections with respect to the first and second side walls of the pickup truck. The second panel section of the plurality of panel sections is pivotally attached to the first panel section. The second latching assembly is attached to the second panel section of the plurality of panel sections, and is configured to selectively secure and release the second panel section of the plurality of panel sections with respect to the first and second side walls of the pickup truck. Each of the first and second latching assemblies include first and second pinch latch assemblies. The first pinch latch assembly of the first and second latching assemblies is located adjacent the first upward-extending side wall of the pickup truck. The second pinch latch assembly of the first and second latching assemblies is located adjacent the second upward-extending side wall of the pickup truck. Each of the first and second pinch latch assemblies comprise: a latch handle portion and an inner pinch handle portion; wherein the latch handle portion includes a latch, a latch handle, at least one spring pocket located between the latch and the latch handle, and at least one guide tab extending away from the latch; and at least one spring that fits into the at least one spring pocket of the latch handle portion. The inner pinch handle portion includes a handle and at least one slot configured to receive at least a portion of the at least one guide tab of the latch handle portion. The handle of the latch handle portion is selectively separated from the handle of the inner pinch handle portion. Such separation is at least in part defined by interaction between the portion of the at least one guide tab of the latch handle portion located in the at least one slot of the inner pinch handle portion. The at least one spring is located in the at least one spring pocket of latch handle portion biases the latch of the latch handle portion toward a latched condition such that when a force is applied to draw the handle of the latch handle portion and the handle of the inner pinch handle portion toward each other. The at least one spring creates a resistance force against the force but is overcome by the force such that movement of the handle of the latch handle portion and the handle of the inner pinch handle portion toward each other moves the latch of the latch handle portion to an unlatched condition. A longitudinally extending connector is attached to the inner pinch handle portion of the first pinch latch assembly and the inner pinch handle portion of the second pinch latch assembly such that when the inner pinch handle portion of the first pinch latch assembly is moved by the force applied to the handle of the latch handle portion and the handle of the inner pinch handle portion toward each other, the inner pinch handle portion of the second pinch latch assembly is caused to move which moves the latch of the latch handle portion of the second pinch latch assembly to the unlatched condition. The at least one spring of the latch handle portion of both of the first and second pinch latch assemblies are configured to move the handle of the latch handle portion and the handle of the inner pinch handle portion so that the latch of the latch handle portion of the both of the first and second pinch latch assemblies are moved back to the latched condition when the force applied to the handle of the latch handle portion and the handle of the inner pinch handle portion is ceased.

(4) In the above another embodiment, the tonneau cover may further comprise: the longitudinally-extending connector being selected from the group consisting of a panel, a bar, and a rod; the plurality of panel sections each includes a frame, a portion of which is located adjacent the first and second latching assemblies, and wherein the longitudinally-extending connector moves the inner pinch handle portion of the first pinch handle assembly when the inner pinch handle portion of the second pinch handle assembly is manually moved; a latch guide located adjacent the latch handle portion and is stationary with retrospect to the latch handle portion, and which engages the at least one spring to produce the resistance force against the force; when the force applied to the handle of the latch portion is ceased, the latch handle portion of the first and second pinch latch assemblies both move to the latched condition; the latch guide includes an opening to accommodate movement of the latch of the latch handle portion with respect to the latch guide; the inner pinch handle

portion includes a cavity illustratively configured to hold a structure selected from the group consisting of a light and a cover; the first and second latching assemblies are positioned substantially flush with their respective frames of the first and second panel sections; a first rail extending longitudinally along a longitudinal extent of the first upwardly-extending side wall, wherein the first rail includes a clip for each latch of the latch handle portion of the first pinch latch assembly, wherein the latch is configured to selectively engage the clip when the latch handle portion is located in the latched condition.

(5) Another illustrative embodiment of the pickup truck includes a tonneau cover which comprises: a first panel section pivotable with respect to the opposing first and second upward-extending side walls; a first latching assembly that attaches to the first panel section and is configured to selectively secure and release the first panel section with respect to the first and second side walls of the pickup truck; the first latching assembly includes first and second pinch latch assemblies; the first pinch latch assembly is located adjacent the first upward-extending side wall of the pickup truck and the second pinch latch assembly is located adjacent the second upward-extending side wall of the pickup truck; the first pinch latch assembly is located on the first panel section located spaced apart and opposite the second pinch latch assembly; each of the first and second pinch latch assemblies comprise: a latch handle portion and an inner handle portion; the latch handle portion includes a latch, a pocket, and a guide; the inner handle portion includes a slot configured to receive at least a portion of the guide of the latch handle portion; a spring that fits into the pocket of the latch handle portion; and a longitudinally extending connector attached to both the first pinch latch assembly and the second pinch latch assembly; wherein the spring biases the latch of the latch handle portion toward a latched condition such that when a force is applied to the latch handle portion or the inner handle portion, the spring creates a resistance force against the force but is overcome by the force such that movement of the latch handle portion moves the latch of the latch handle portion to an unlatched condition; wherein both the first pinch latch assembly and the second pinch latch assembly are moved by the force applied to the latch handle portion or the inner pinch handle portion which causes the inner handle portion of the second pinch latch assembly to move the latch of the latch handle portion of the second pinch latch assembly to the unlatched condition; and wherein the spring is configured to move the latch handle portion and the inner handle portion so that the latch of the latch handle portion is moved back to the latched condition when the force applied to the latch handle portion or the inner handle portion is ceased.

(6) In the above another embodiment, the tonneau cover may further comprise: the latch handle portion further includes a latch handle and at least one spring pocket located between the latch and the latch handle, wherein the guide extends away from the latch, and a spring that fits into the pocket of the latch handle portion; and the handle of the latch handle portion is selectively separated from the handle of the inner handle portion, wherein such separation is at least in part defined by interaction between the portion of the guide of the latch handle portion located in the slot of the inner handle portion.

(7) Another illustrative embodiment of the pickup truck includes a tonneau cover which comprises: a first panel section pivotable with respect to the opposing first and second upward-extending side walls; a first latching assembly attached to the first panel section and is configured to selectively secure and release the first panel section with respect to the first and second side walls of the pickup truck; the first latching assembly includes first and second pinch latch assemblies; the first pinch latch assembly is located adjacent the first upward-extending side wall of the pickup truck and the second pinch latch assembly is located adjacent the second upward-extending side wall of the pickup truck; each of the first and second pinch latch assemblies comprise: a latch handle portion and an inner pinch handle portion; and when a force is applied to the first pinch latch assembly it moves to an unlatched condition.

(8) In the above another embodiment, the tonneau cover may further comprise: a second panel section of the plurality of panel sections which is pivotally attached to the first panel section; a

second latching assembly attached to the second panel section of the plurality of panel sections and configured to selectively secure and release the second panel section of the plurality of panel sections with respect to the first and second side walls of the pickup truck; and wherein each of the first and second latching assemblies include first and second pinch latch assemblies; the latch handle portion includes a latch, a latch handle, at least one spring pocket located between the latch and the latch handle, at least one guide extending away from the latch; and at least one spring that fits into the at least one spring pocket of the latch handle portion; the inner pinch handle portion includes a handle and at least one slot configured to receive at least a portion of the at least one guide tab of the latch handle portion; the handle of the latch handle portion is selectively separated from the handle of the inner pinch handle portion, wherein such separation is at least in part defined by interaction between the portion of the at least one guide tab of the latch handle portion located in the at least one slot of the inner pinch handle portion; the at least one spring located in the at least one spring pocket of latch handle portion biases the latch of the latch handle portion toward a latched condition such that when a force is applied to draw the handle of the latch handle portion and the handle of the inner pinch handle portion toward each other, the at least one spring creates a resistance force against the force but is overcome by the force such that movement of the handle of the latch handle portion and the handle of the inner pinch handle portion toward each other moves the latch of the latch handle portion to an unlatched condition; a longitudinally extending connector attached to the inner pinch handle portion of the first pinch latch assembly and the inner pinch handle portion of the second pinch latch assembly such that when the inner pinch handle portion of the first pinch latch assembly is moved by the force applied to the handle of the latch handle portion and the handle of the inner pinch handle portion toward each other, the inner pinch handle portion of the second pinch latch assembly is caused to move which moves the latch of the latch handle portion of the second pinch latch assembly to the unlatched condition; and the at least one spring of the latch handle portion of both of the first and second pinch latch assemblies are configured to move the handle of the latch handle portion and the handle of the inner pinch handle portion so that the latch of the latch handle portion of the both of the first and second pinch latch assemblies are moved back to the latched condition when the force applied to the handle of the latch handle portion and the handle of the inner pinch handle portion is ceased.

(9) Additional features and advantages of the tonneau cover will become apparent to those skilled in the art upon consideration of the following detailed descriptions exemplifying the best mode of carrying out the tonneau cover as presently perceived.

Description

DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

- (1) The present disclosure will be described hereafter with reference to the attached drawings which are given as non-limiting examples only, in which:
- (2) FIG. 1 is a rear perspective view of a truck with accompanying truck bed having an illustrative embodiment of a tonneau cover attached thereto;
- (3) FIG. 2 is another rear perspective view of the truck bed with the tonneau thereon with one of its panels in a folded-back position;
- (4) FIG. 3 is another rear perspective view of the first and second panels in their folded back condition;
- (5) FIG. 4 is another rear perspective view of the truck with a tonneau cover in the folded up condition;
- (6) FIG. 5 is an underside perspective view of a panel section of the tonneau cover;
- (7) FIGS. 6A and 6B are underside, detail, and cross-sectional views of a panel of the tonneau cover;

- (8) FIG. 7 is an exploded view of the latch and pinch handle assembly;
- (9) FIG. 8 is an isolated perspective view of the latch and pinch handle assembly;
- (10) FIGS. 9A and 9B demonstrate operation of the latch and pinch handles;
- (11) FIGS. 10A and 10B are additional views showing the operation of the latch and pinch handles;
- (12) FIG. 11 is a perspective cross-sectional view of a portion of the panel section with the latch and pinch handle assembly fitted therein;
- (13) FIG. 12 is an underside view of the latch and pinch handle assemblies used with a panel;
- (14) FIG. 13 is a partial end detail view of a panel portion of a tonneau cover;
- (15) FIG. 14 is an underside partial perspective view of a portion of the panel section of the of the tonneau cover showing the latch and pinch handle assembly;
- (16) FIGS. 15A and 15B show portions of the pinch handle portion of the latch and pinch handle assembly;
- (17) FIG. 16 is a side perspective view of the latch and pinch handle assembly;
- (18) FIG. 17 is a underside perspective view of a portion of a panel section from the tonneau cover showing a light with the latch and pinch handle assembly;
- (19) FIG. 18 is a partially exploded view showing the light and the inner pinch handle;
- (20) FIG. 19 is a side view of a portion of the truck showing the tonneau cover located in its raised stowed position supported by a gusset;
- (21) FIG. 20 is a perspective view of the tonneau cover located in its stowed position similar to FIG. 19;
- (22) FIG. 21 is a detail view of the connection portion of the gusset and tonneau cover from FIG. 20;
- (23) FIG. 22 is an underside view of the tonneau cover showing the gusset located in its stowed position;
- (24) FIG. 23 is a detail perspective view of a portion of the tonneau, again showing the gusset located in its stowed position;
- (25) FIGS. 24A and B are end sectional views showing the gusset coupled to the side rail;
- (26) FIG. 25 is a side cross-sectional view of the hinge assembly also showing the hinge seal and a hinge seal spacer;
- (27) FIG. 26 is a cross-sectional end view of a hinge located between panels;
- (28) FIG. 27 is a perspective, partially exploded view of a portion of the panel with the hinge and end cap;
- (29) FIG. 28 is a perspective view of a portion of the side bed rail with a clamp assembly attached thereto;
- (30) FIG. 29 is a perspective view of a portion of the tonneau cover panels attached to the side bed rail;
- (31) FIG. 30 is a cross-sectional view showing the side bed rail for attaching to a truck bed side wall with a portion of a panel and D-seal;
- (32) FIG. 31 is a perspective detail view of a portion of the tonneau cover located in its raised stowed position;
- (33) FIG. 32 is a detail end view of the tonneau cover shown in FIG. 31;
- (34) FIG. 33 is a perspective detail view of the buckle pocket; and
- (35) FIG. 34 is a perspective view of the buckle assembly.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(36) The figures and descriptions provided herein may have been simplified to illustrate aspects that are relevant for a clear understanding of the herein described apparatuses, systems, and methods, while eliminating, for the purpose of clarity, other aspects that may be found in typical similar devices, systems, and methods. Those of ordinary skill may thus recognize that other elements and/or operations may be desirable and/or necessary to implement the devices, systems, and methods described herein. But because such elements and operations are known in the art, and

because they do not facilitate a better understanding of the present disclosure, for the sake of brevity a discussion of such elements and operations may not be provided herein. However, the present disclosure is deemed to nevertheless include all such elements, variations, and modifications to the described aspects that would be known to those of ordinary skill in the art.

(37) Embodiments are provided throughout so that this disclosure is sufficiently thorough and fully conveys the scope of the disclosed embodiments to those who are skilled in the art. Numerous specific details are set forth, such as examples of specific components, devices, and methods, to provide a thorough understanding of embodiments of the present disclosure. Nevertheless, it will be apparent to those skilled in the art that certain specific disclosed details need not be employed, and that embodiments may be embodied in different forms. As such, the embodiments should not be construed to limit the scope of the disclosure. As referenced above, in some embodiments, well-known processes, well-known device structures, and well-known technologies may not be described in detail.

(38) The terminology used herein is for the purpose of describing particular embodiments only and is not intended to be limiting. For example, as used herein, the singular forms “a”, “an” and “the” may be intended to include the plural forms as well, unless the context clearly indicates otherwise. The terms “comprises,” “comprising,” “including,” and “having,” are inclusive and therefore specify the presence of stated features, integers, steps, operations, elements, and/or components, but do not preclude the presence or addition of one or more other features, integers, steps, operations, elements, components, and/or groups thereof. The steps, processes, and operations described herein are not to be construed as necessarily requiring their respective performance in the particular order discussed or illustrated, unless specifically identified as a preferred or required order of performance. It is also to be understood that additional or alternative steps may be employed, in place of or in conjunction with the disclosed aspects.

(39) When an element or layer is referred to as being “on”, “upon”, “connected to” or “coupled to” another element or layer, it may be directly on, upon, connected or coupled to the other element or layer, or intervening elements or layers may be present, unless clearly indicated otherwise. In contrast, when an element or layer is referred to as being “directly on,” “directly upon”, “directly connected to” or “directly coupled to” another element or layer, there may be no intervening elements or layers present. Other words used to describe the relationship between elements should be interpreted in a like fashion (e.g., “between” versus “directly between,” “adjacent” versus “directly adjacent,” etc.). Further, as used herein the term “and/or” includes any and all combinations of one or more of the associated listed items.

(40) Yet further, although the terms first, second, third, etc. may be used herein to describe various elements, components, regions, layers and/or sections, these elements, components, regions, layers and/or sections should not be limited by these terms. These terms may be only used to distinguish one element, component, region, layer or section from another element, component, region, layer or section. Terms such as “first,” “second,” and other numerical terms when used herein do not imply a sequence or order unless clearly indicated by the context. Thus, a first element, component, region, layer or section discussed below could be termed a second element, component, region, layer or section without departing from the teachings of the embodiments.

(41) A perspective rear view of a truck **2** with accompanying truck bed **4** comprising side walls **6** and **8** is shown in FIG. **1**. Also, spanning side walls **6** and **8** to cover same is a truck bed or tonneau cover **10**. Illustratively, cover **10** is made up of a plurality of panel sections **12**, **14**, and **16**, that are movable to allow access to bed **4** underneath. A base panel **18** is illustratively attached over bed **4** but is not movable to reveal bed **4** below. Instead, base panel **18** is employed to allow the other panel sections **12**, **14**, and **16** to pivot with respect to it as well as assist panel sections **12**, **14**, and **16** in being stored in an open/upright position with respect to bed **4**. Illustrative features of cover **10** include, but are not limited to, a latching assembly **20**, a vertical support gusset assembly **22** (see FIG. **19**), a securement system **24** (see FIG. **31**), a hinge assembly **26** with a hinge seal spacer **234**

and seal rods **252** (see FIGS. **25** and **26**), and improved side rails **109**, **110** (see FIG. **28**).

(42) Another perspective view of truck **2** showing cover **10** over bed **4**, but with panel section **12** folded back over panel section **14** is shown in FIG. **2**. Panel section **12** pivots about hinge assembly **26**. Also shown in this view is latching assembly **20**, configured to secure and release panel section **12** from side walls **6** and **8** (see also FIG. **1**).

(43) Another perspective view of truck **2** is shown with panel sections **12** and **14**, each with a latching assembly **20**, and shown being raised to further uncover bed **4**. This view demonstrates how pivoting about hinge assembly **26** allows the continued folding up of the cover panels to open up truck bed **4**.

(44) Another real perspective view of truck **2** is shown in FIG. **4**. This view demonstrates how the panel sections such as panel section **14** may be pivoted upwardly in a vertical direction about hinge assembly **26** further uncovering bed **4**. Also shown in this view is latching assembly **20**.

Illustratively, each panel section includes its own latching assembly to secure each panel section to truck **2**.

(45) Latching assembly **20** is the mechanism by which each panel section latches or secures to the vehicle to hold the panel section and, therefore, the cover (when all panel sections are latched) in place. In the illustrative embodiment, latching assembly **20** includes a pinch handle assembly located on each side of the panel section configured so that if one pinch handle is activated, it will not only move the latch closest to it, but will also move the latch distal from it so both latches are disengaged by actuating a single pinch handle.

(46) In a further embodiment, the pinch handles may be attached to the frame portions of the panel sections and have a cover that may illustratively double as a connector piece allowing actuation of one pinch handle to also actuate the other pinch handle. The latching assemblies may further include integrated lights and engage a gusset or other support structure to hold the panel sections vertical when the cover is open.

(47) An underside perspective view of a panel section such as section **12** is shown in FIG. **5**. This section includes frame **32** disposed about the general periphery of panel section **12** outlining panel **34**. A flange edge **36** may extend from panel **34** and frame **32** about the periphery of panel section **12** to provide further covering and sealing capabilities between the cover and side walls (and tail gate) of the truck. It is appreciated that other panel sections **14** and **16** (not shown in this view, see FIG. **1**) that are not the end most panel section **12** may have a flanged edge at their sides since they have a hinge on both of their ends. Accordingly, the illustrated panel section includes flange edge **36** extending from the periphery frame **32**. As this is the furthest most panel from the cab of the vehicle, this portion of flange edge **36** may cover the seam between the tonneau cover and the tail gate. Also on the opposing end of panel section **12** is hinge assembly **26**. As will be discussed further herein, hinge assembly **26** allows each panel section to be folded flat over another panel section and also folded up about vertical on base panel **18** to a stowed position.

(48) Latching assembly **20** is shown integrated with underside frame **32**, and illustratively including pinch latch assemblies **38** and **40**. In an illustrative embodiment, pinch latch assemblies **38** and **40** each include latch handles **42** and **44** such that when pinched inward, they also move latches **46** and **48** illustratively inward to release same from clips mounted on the rails attached to side walls **6** and **8**. A connector panel **50** illustratively attaches to both pinch latch assemblies **38** and **40**. As discussed further herein, connector panel **50** is configured to move if either pinch latch assembly **38** or **40** is moved to unlatch its corresponding latch. Because connector panel **50** is connected to both assemblies, movement of the one assembly will cause the other assembly to move which in turn will pull the other latch releasing the same from the clip. This has the net effect of being able to activate just one of the pinch latch assemblies **38** or **40** to activate both latches **46** and **48** to disengage same from their corresponding rail clips. By doing this, the panel section can be moved. Accordingly, an operator needs to only be on one side of the vehicle bed to fully unlatch a panel section and move it out of the way.

(49) Additional illustrative views of panel section **12** are shown in FIGS. **6A** and **6B**. These views specifically show front and side sectional views of pinch latch assembly **38**. As shown in FIG. **6A**, latch handles **42** and **44** are spaced apart from each other. As further shown herein, they are spring loaded so pinching them together will be illustratively against the bias of the spring. This will cause latch **46** to move inward which will disengage a clip attached to the rail which attaches to the side wall of the truck bed. The cross-sectional view also illustrates how pinch latching assembly **38** (as well as the others for that matter) may be part of frame **32** of panel section **12**.

(50) This illustrative embodiment also shows a light **52**. Because these latch assemblies are located on the underside of the panel sections toward the interior of truck bed **4**, these panel sections may block out some light. Light **52** positioned proximal to the latching assemblies allow locating the same easier while providing illumination inside the truck bed. This may be particularly useful if the panel section is lowered to its used position covering the truck bed.

(51) An exploded view of pinch latching assembly **38** is shown in FIG. **7**. It is appreciated that the latching assemblies on each side of the panel section may be similar except for the positions of the corresponding latch and connector panel attachments. They are essentially positioned in reverse as shown herein. The primary components of this latch assembly **38** include latch pinch handle portion **54** and inner pinch handle **56**. Latch handle portion **54** includes latch handle **42**, spring pockets **58** and **60**, spacer **62** and latch **46**, and guide tabs **64** and **66**. Inner pinch handle **56** may include a cavity **68** illustratively configured to hold a light, cover, or other structure. Handle **44** extends from inner pinch handle **56**. A connector panel attachment tab **70** is located opposite latch **46** and configured to attach connector panel **50** to the opposing latching assembly. A latch guide **72** is attached to frame **32** (see also FIG. **11**) or like portion of the panel section and receives latch springs **74** and **76**. Additionally, springs **74** and **76** fit into spring pockets **58** and **60**, respectively, of latch handle portion **54**. Springs **74** and **76** bias against walls **78** and **80** of latch guide **72** as well as walls **82** and **84** of latch handle portion **54** to create a resistance force against the motion of travel that pulls latch **46** to the unlatching position (see also FIGS. **9** and **10**). Guide tabs **64** and **66** fit in respective slots **86** and **88** in inner pinch handle **56** guides movement of inner pinch handle **56** which pulls on connector panel **50** causing the opposed latching assembly to unlatch as well. It is appreciated that the latch assemblies on the other panel sections may operate the same as described herein with pinch latching assembly **38**.

(52) A perspective view of pinch latch assembly **40** is shown in FIG. **16**. Pinch latch assembly **40** is similar to that of pinch latch assembly **38** except it is oriented in reverse to latch the opposite side wall with latch **48**. Otherwise, the structures as shown, such as spring pocket **60**, latch handles **42** and **44**, slot **88** of inner pinch handle **56** are the same as that of latch assembly **38** but operate in mirror image to same.

(53) It is further appreciated that because each of the pinch latching assemblies **38** and **40** (see, also FIG. **5**) have their own springs **74**, **76** that bias in opposite directions, they cause latch handles **42** and **44** to bias away from each other. Pinching handles **42** and **44** together is what causes both latches **46** and **48** to move to the unlatched position (see, also, FIGS. **9** and **10**). In other words, pinching handles **42** and **44** of assembly **38** towards each other compresses springs **74**, **76** pulling latch **46** inward against the spring bias to the unlatched position. Because latching assembly **38** also pulls on the other latching assembly **40** via connector panel **50**, latching assembly **40** compresses its springs **74**, **76** in an opposite direction from springs **74**, **76** of latching assembly **38**. A tension from both spring sets is created that creates the resistance force on handles **42** and **44** which move latches **46**, **48** to the unlatched position, and biases latches **46** and **48** back toward their original latched position.

(54) A perspective view of pinch latching assembly **38** is shown in FIG. **8**. This view depicts the relative positioning of the structures as discussed in FIG. **7**. As shown, latch guide **72** shrouds a portion of latch handle portion **54**, and includes opening **90** to accommodate movement of latch **46** in directions **92** and **93**. Latch handles **42** and **44** are separated from each other by guide tabs **64**

and **66**, each located in slots **86** and **88**, respectively. Connector panel **50** is shown attached to connector panel attachment tab **70**. Spring tabs **94** and **96** (see also FIG. 7) serve to reduce vibration in the latching assembly. Also shown in these views are pockets **98** and **100** illustratively sized to accommodate fingers to aid in moving latch handles **42** and **44**.

(55) Side views of pinch latch assemblies **38** and **40** are shown in FIGS. **9** and **10** demonstrating how they operate. As shown in FIG. **9A**, both pinch latch assemblies **38** and **40** have their latches **46** and **48** located in their extended latched position. This means when the panel sections are secured in a latched position, that portion of the cover is latched to clips on the rails of the truck bed side walls. To unlatch both pinch latch assemblies **38** and **40** at the same time, latch handles **42** and **44** can be pinched together in directions **93** and **92** by hand **102**. This causes latch handle portion to move in direction **93** while inner pinch handle **56** moves in direction **92**. This causes latch **46** to also move in direction **93** relative to latch guide **72**, having the effect of pulling it away from the rail clip, thereby providing clearance to lift on the panel section. The resistance caused by springs **74** and **76** (see also FIG. 7) creates both a resistant force on the fingers when moving latch handles **42** and **44**, and causes latch **46** to snap back in direction **92** towards the clip to return latch **46** to its latching condition without further operator effort. At the same time, with inner latch pinch handle moving in direction **92**, it pulls on pinch latch assembly **40** in direction **92** as well. This causes inner pinch handle **56** from pinch latch assembly **40** to be pulled in direction **92** which also pulls latch handle portion **54** of pinch latch assembly **40** in direction **92** as well via guide tabs **64** and **66** (see also FIG. 7). As shown in FIG. **9B**, inner pinch handle **56** pulls on guide tabs **64** and **66** to essentially pull latch **48** from the clip and the side rail, thereby moving latch **48** to its unlatched position. It is, therefore, appreciable from these two views how pinching the latch assembly on one side, not only moves the latch on that side to the unlatched position, but moves the latch on the other side to the unlatched position as well. Again, this has the effect of being able to unlatch both sides of a panel section from just one side of same.

(56) Conversely, as shown in similar views in FIG. **10**, hand activation of pinch latch assembly **40** may actuate not only latch **48** but latch **46** on pinch latch assembly **38** as well. As shown in FIG. **10A**, pinch latch assemblies **38** and **40** are both in the latched condition similar to that shown in FIG. **9A**. This time, when hand **102** pinches latch handles **42** and **44** in directions **92** and **93**, respectively, latch **48** has moved in direction **92** as well, recessing it in latch guide **72**. Again, this is the recessed condition for pinch latch assembly **40**. At the same time, guide tab **64** pulls on inner pinch handle **56** which pulls on the corresponding inner pinch handle **56** of pinch latch assembly **38**. This pulls on guide tab **64** to pull latch handle portions **54** in direction **93** thereby pulling latch **46** in direction **93** as well. Clearing it from the clip on the side rail thereby now being positioned in its unlatched condition.

(57) A cut-away perspective detail view of panel sections **12** and **14** are shown in FIG. **11**. This view shows how connector panel **50** fits in a pinch handle channel **104** formed in a portion of frame **32** in each of panel section **12** and **14**. Adjacent pinch channel handle is hinge assembly **26** that hingedly connects the panel sections together. Pinch latch assembly **38** is shown including latch handles **42** and **44** and latch guide **72**. Clip **106** is shown attached to rail **110**. Latch **48** (not visible in this view) engages clip **106** to secure the panel section to the vehicle. This view further illustrates how the panel sections may be constructed. As shown, panel member **112** is fitted in a receptacle **115** of hinge assembly **26**. The same is illustratively the case with panel member **114** fitting in receptacle **117** of frame **32**.

(58) An underside view of latch assembly **20** is shown in FIG. **12**. This view illustrates the configuration of two pinch latch assemblies **38** and **40** with connector panel **50** extending between and connecting them together. It is appreciated that a latching assembly is attachable to each of the panel sections **12**, **14**, and **16** to secure and release them. Also shown in this view are lights **52** and latches **46** and **48**.

(59) A partial end view of tonneau cover **10** isolated from truck **2** is shown in FIG. **13**. This view

shows how latching assembly **20** fits essentially flush with frame **32** of panel section **12** (same applies to the other panel sections) with extending latch handles **42** and **44** extending downwardly as a touch point for easy locating and accessing. As further shown in the illustrative embodiment, all the latching assemblies are aligned behind the first one to maintain a consistent location of touch points to also make it easy to locate and activate additional panel sections once the first panel section is folded up. Flange edge **36** is shown extending from the edge of frame **32** and illustratively extending over rail **110**. In the illustrated embodiment, clip **106** along with clip **108** are fitted in a logistic track **118** of rail **110**. Clips **106** and **108** are configured to receive the latches from the latch assemblies at a location extended outward and above logistic track **118** and rail **110**. Additionally, a plurality of rail brackets, such as rail brackets **120** and **122** shown, each include hook portion **128** configured to engage rail flanges **130** on rail **110**. Rail brackets **120** and **122** also include joints **132** and **134** to movably engage arms **136** and **138**, respectively, to help brackets **120** and **122** secure to the side wall of truck **2**. It is contemplated that truck side walls come in different sizes and configurations. The adjustability of brackets **120** and **122** allow engagement with any variety of such bed walls. Fastener assembly **140**, which includes a bolt **142** and fastener receptacle **144** is configured to securely fasten rail **110** to the side wall of a truck bed using rail brackets **120** and **122**. It is appreciated that additional brackets may be used if needed to secure the rail.

(60) An underside partial perspective view of a panel section with latching assembly **20** attached to frame **32** is shown in FIG. **14**. This view depicts how latch handles **42** and **44** serve as touch points to engage for unlatching the panel section. The view also shows latch **48** engaged with clip **106** to secure the panel section to the bed wall. As shown in this illustrative embodiment, clip **106** is attached to logistic track **118** and rail **110** via fastener **146**. It is appreciated that other attachment means may be used to attach the clip to the rail. It is further appreciated that the clip is adjustable along the rail to conform the tonneau cover to the particular size of the truck bed.

(61) Perspective views of portions of pinch latch assemblies **38** and **40** are shown in FIGS. **15A** and **B** respectively. These views show spring tabs **94** and **96** on inner pinch handle **56** for each pinch latch assemblies **38** and **40**. Spring tabs **94** and **96** are located in proximity to connector panel attachments **70** and press against connector panel **50** (see FIG. **11**) when attached to connector panel attachment tabs **70** to minimize movement and noise by the latching assembly while the truck is moving. The view in FIG. **15** further shows how pinch latching assembly **40** fits into pinch handle channel **104** (pinch latch assembly **38** operating the same way).

(62) An underside detail perspective view of a portion of panel section **12** is shown in FIG. **17**. This view further demonstrates how pinch latch assembly **38** fits into frame **32**. Such recess allows latch **46** to engage the clip such as clip **106** underneath the panel section, which is helpful for security. Such recess also allows for an unobstructed use of the truck's cargo area. Having no protrusions extending from the cover means no obstructions from the cover when loading or unloading the truck.

(63) Also shown in FIG. **17** is flange edge **36**. Unique to panel section **12**, which is the end-most panel located not only adjacent the side walls but also the tailgate, may illustratively include a gasket seal **148** to assist sealing between the top edge of the tailgate and the cover. This assists preventing water from seeping in between the two structures. It is also appreciated that by "seal" it is not intended to mean a seal to the extent the interior of the truck bed necessarily becomes an air tight vessel. Also shown in this view is light **52**.

(64) A partial exploded view of inner pinch handle **56** with light **52** is shown in FIG. **18**. This view demonstrates how light **52** is configured to fit into cavity **68** of inner pinch handle **56**. Again, the proximity of the light to the pinch handle not only provides illumination to the inside of the truck bed, but may also serve as a location indicator for the pinch handles. Even further, light **52** may be removable as shown and serve as a flashlight. It is appreciated that light **52** may be battery operated, have manual on/off switch or a sensor switch to activate upon some occurrence such as hand movement.

(65) As previously discussed, tonneau cover **10** includes panel sections **12**, **14**, and **16** that are folded up to be stored in vertical fashion on base panel section **18**. In order to assist holding the panel sections upright, a vertical gusset assembly **22** (see FIG. **19**) may be employed. When not in use, gusset assembly **22** stows under the panel section frame. The gusset assembly moves in the direction of the width of the bed rather than the length of the bed. In other words, to move the gusset between use and stowed positions, it is rotated about an axis that is longitudinal to the truck bed instead of lateral. Latches **46** and **48** may be employed to hold the gusset in place while the panel sections are positioned vertically. Lastly, they are designed to be quickly attached and removed making the process convenient.

(66) A side detail view of a portion of the truck showing tonneau cover **10** with its panel sections **12**, **14**, and **16** raised to their stowed position on base panel **18**, and supported by gusset assembly **22**, is shown in FIG. **19**. As demonstrated in this view, a gusset **150** is coupled to both rail **109** and latch **46**. This arrangement provides both horizontal and vertical securement means cover **10** will be held vertically in place. This arrangement may be employed on rail **110** as well.

(67) A detail perspective view of a portion of cover **10** with gusset assembly **22** coupled thereto is shown in FIG. **20**. This view depicts how gusset **150** is a panel that has a lower end **152** that fits into a logistic track on rail **109** and is positioned upward so it will engage latch **46**. It is appreciated that although the description with gusset **22** is made relative to latch **46** and panel section **16**, gusset assembly **22** may be applicable to latch **48** on the other panel sections as well. In any event, gusset **150** includes an aperture **154** configured to receive latch **46**. Accordingly, gusset **150** is able to hold the panel sections upright. In an illustrative embodiment, a handle **156** is part of gusset **150** allowing an operator to more easily hold and manipulate the gusset.

(68) When not in use, gusset **150** is configured to pivot towards space **158** in bed **4** to be stowed out of the way underneath the section panels. In other words, the gusset may be supported underneath the panel assembly when not in use and then pivoted upwards to hold the panel sections in an upright position when in use.

(69) A detail perspective view of a portion of tonneau cover **10** folded over in its upright position with latch **46** engaged in aperture **154** of gusset **150** is shown in FIG. **21**. As depicted, operator's hand **102** can activate pinch latch assembly **38** to cause latch **46** to engage aperture **154**. It is appreciated from the description of the operation of latching assembly **20** that when gusset assemblies **22** are on both sides of cover **10**, actuating one latch to engage the aperture in one gusset may also actuate the opposed latch to engage the opposed gusset. It is further appreciated that only one gusset may be used. In another embodiment, a plurality of gusset assemblies may be used. In addition, because pinch latch assembly **38** is spring loaded, physical actuation of latch handles **42** and **44** may not always be necessary. Pushing the gusset into cavity **160** as part of frame **32**, drives the periphery of aperture **154** against spring loaded latch **46**. Because of the biasing of the springs and pinch latch assembly **38**, once latch **46** has cleared the periphery in aperture **154**, it will extend back and latch cover **10** to gusset **150**. It is further appreciated that because gusset **150** may slide along the rails attached to the side walls of the bed, gusset **150** may be usable to hold either of panel sections **12**, **14**, or **16**. This view further shows a hinge assembly **26** attached to panel sections **14** and **16** with panel section **12** located there between.

(70) An underside perspective view of tonneau cover **10** with gusset assembly **22** located underneath in a stowed position is shown in FIG. **22**. As depicted, gusset **150** attaches to its lower end **152**, which engages a logistic track **160** in rail **109** and located underneath panel section **16**. Gusset assembly **22** may slide along the logistic track **160** to its desired location, and then pivot upward in direction **162** to its use position and then back down in direction **164** to its stowed position.

(71) A detail perspective view of a portion of gusset assembly **22** located underneath panel section **16** is shown in FIG. **23**. This view shows how a clip **166** may be used to support a portion of gusset **150** while in its lowered, stowed position. This view also shows aperture **154**. It is appreciated that

clip **166** may be moved to any location along rail **109** so that gusset may be positioned along any desired part thereon.

(72) End sectional detail views showing a portion of gusset assembly **22** are shown at FIGS. **24A** and **B**. Lower end **152** of gusset **150** illustratively includes a pivot joint **168** coupled to pivot cap **170**. Illustratively extending from pivot joint **168** is arm **172** that extends into logistic track **118** of side rail **109**. A fastener **174** selectively secures arm **172** to logistic track **118**. In the illustrated view, not only is gusset **150** pivotable in directions **162** and **164**, but it is also slidable on pivot joint **168** in directions transverse to **162** and **164**. This allows gusset **150** and lower end **152** to be removable. Further, lower end **152** includes stops **176** and **177** that abut arm **172** on pivot joint **168** to limit the degree to which gusset **150** can pivot in directions **162** and **164**. Pivot joint **168** and arm **172** are removable from logistic track **118** by loosening fastener **174**. In this illustrated embodiment, there is enough clearance in the opening **180** of logistic track **118** to lift ball joint **168** and arm **172** in direction **182**. In addition, the end of arm **172** has an arcuate surface **186**, which is located opposite an abutment **188**. To remove pivot joint **168** after fastener **174** is loosened, arm **172** is raised in direction **182** and then pivoted in direction **162**. The logistic track **180** is sized so that arcuate surface **186** will pivot out of opening **180** to permit removal of pivot joint **168**.

(73) A side cross-sectional view of a hinge assembly **26** is shown in FIG. **25**. The hinge assemblies attach to frames **32** which couple to hinges to illustrative panels **112**, **114**, and **116** (panels not shown in this view). In addition, and as originally described with respect to FIG. **11**, frame **32** proximate to the hinge assembly, at least starting with panel section **14**, frame assembly **32**, attaches to latching assembly **20**. In the illustrated embodiment, hinge assembly **26** includes bracket portions **190** to add structure to latching assembly **20** and frame **32**. Adjacent bracket portion **190** is hinge bracket section **198**. It is appreciated that each hinge bracket on each side of hinge assembly **26** may be identical and face each other to help create the fully formed hinge. In other embodiments, one hinge bracket may be constructed differently than the opposing hinge bracket. In any event, as the illustrated embodiment shows, hinge bracket **198** includes a hinge rod cavity **200**, a slot **202** adjacent to hinge rod cavity **200** and illustratively partially formed thereby. Slot **202** is also defined by finger portion **204** and angled digit **206**. An opposed finger portion **208** faces angled digit **206** with an opening **210** located there between. Extending from slot **202** and opposing finger portion as shown is arm **212**. At its end, arm **212** includes an angled digit **214** that faces a portion of angled digit **206** with opening **210** located there between and forming another cavity **216** between angled digit **214** and opposed finger portion **208**. As shown opposite angled digit **214** is flange member **218** with a tab **220** extending therefrom. In the illustrative embodiment, the opposing hinge bracket **198** includes the same structures, so when facing each other those structures are mirror images of each other.

(74) Located between the opposing hinge brackets **198** is a hinge seal **222** that incorporates a spacer **224**. It is appreciated that hinge seal **222** may be made of a resilient material including but not limited to natural or synthetic rubber or silicone. Each side of hinge seal **222** includes a curled finger **226** that is disposed through opening **210**, extends into slot **202**, and wraps towards angled digit **206**. Additionally, in an illustrative embodiment, a tab **228** extends from spacer **224** in order to provide an exterior seal for the hinge. Curled finger **226** also includes an opposed tab **230** that fits into slot **202** adjacent opposing finger portion **208**. It is appreciated that hinge spacer **222** may be symmetrical from the cross-sectional end point of view as shown in FIG. **25**, such that the same previously-described structures appear on the opposite side. Furthermore, because resilient hinge seal **222** bends in directions **230** and **232**, it may serve as the pivot point allowing adjacent panel sections **12** and **14** to fold with respect to each other as well as panel sections **14** and **16**. In addition these structures are longitudinally extending the width of the panel section.

(75) Also shown in this view is a hinge seal spacer **234** engageable with angled digits **214** as well as flange member **218** and tab **220** on each of the opposed hinge brackets **198**. As depicted in this illustrated embodiment, hinge seal spacer **234** is not necessarily symmetrical despite being fitted

into symmetrically arranged structures in hinge assembly **26**. As shown, hinge seal spacer **234** includes a head section **236** that fits in cavity **238** of hinge seal **222**. On one side of the hinge seal spacer there is a tab portion **240** that provides extra pressure on hinge seal **222** by being disposed in opening **210**, angled digit **214** and curled finger **226**. Extending opposite of tab portion **240** is a curled digit **242** that bends around the angling digit **214** on arm **212** as shown. A leg **246** extends from head section **236** of hinge seal spacer **234** terminating at a curled foot **248** on one side and an angled foot **250** as shown. Both engage one of the opposing tab portion **220** on flange member **218** from opposing arm **212**. It is appreciated that when folding the panel sections relative to each other, angled foot **250** causes a snap between the structures when tab **220** moves past. In addition, the spacer helps maintain separation between opposing bracket **198**.

(76) A detailed and cross-sectional view of hinge assembly **26** is shown in FIG. **26**. This view, like the prior view, demonstrates how hinge seal **222** fits between hinge brackets **198**. In addition to hinge seal **222**, hinge seal rods **252** are each located in respective hinge rod cavities **200**. These hinge seal rods **252** each abut curled finger **226** of hinge seal **222** as shown. This abutment provides extra seal properties for hinge seal **222** on each of its sides as shown. Further, engagement between angled digit **206** and curled finger **226** of hinge seal **222** provides extra friction there between to prevent slipping and misalignment.

(77) The perspective detail view of frame **32** along with hinge seal **222** and hinge seal rod **252**, along with end cap **256** is shown in FIG. **27**. End cap **256** may be part of flange edge **36** previously discussed in other views. It is appreciated that hinge seal rod **252** may assist rigidly aligns end cap **256**.

(78) Tonneau cover **10** attaches to the side walls of the truck bed via the side bed rails such as bed rail **109** as previously discussed. Side rail **109** (as well as side rail **110** previously discussed) includes both logistic track **118** to receive clips **106** and **108** as well as an attachment track or rail flange **130** to receive rail brackets **120** and **122** (see FIG. **13**). Side bed rail **109** may have a seal **119** that conforms to the bed wall to assist in better sealment between the cover and the bed wall. Seal **260** on top of rail **109** may be “D”-shaped that conforms to the rail and abuts against a ridge **123** on cover **10**. This reduces the possibility of water entering the bed with the cover closed. Instead, the water drains outside of the cover.

(79) An isolated detail perspective view of a portion of side bed rail **109** is shown in FIG. **28**. As shown, clip **106** (or **108**) fits into logistic track **118** as previously discussed. Rail clamp **120** (or **122**) attaches side bed rail **109** to the bed wall **6** by gripping rail flange **130**. It is appreciated that both clip **106** (or **108**) and clamp **120** (or **122**) may slide along rail **109** (or **110**) until reaching the desired location.

(80) An underside view of a portion of cover **10** attached to rail **109** is shown in FIG. **29**. This view demonstrates how latch **46** secures panel section **12** to the truck bed. Furthermore, it is appreciated from this view how additional clips such as clips **106** and **108** are likewise attached to rail **109** to receive latch **46** from panel section **14**. The view also depicts how cover **10** sets on top of rail **109**.

(81) A cross-sectional end view of side bed rail **109** supporting a panel section is shown in FIG. **30**. This view demonstrates how D-seal **260** sets on shelf **262** supported by the rails. Shelf **262** includes an upturned portion **264** that assists in reducing the ability of water to get into bed **4**. End cap **256** includes a recess **266** that receives D-seal **260**. An end tab **123** on end cap **256** also assists keeping water out. This view further shows the shape of logistic track **118** and attachment track **130**.

(82) Cover **10** includes a securement system **28** to hold the folded panels in an upright position when the cover is open. The securement system includes a bracket illustratively affixed to the base panel where a channel in the bracket receives the folded panel sections and holds them upright. A buckle or similar latching system may then secure the panel sections in that upright position, keeping the cover open. Using the channel bracket also keeps the panel sections off of the surface of the base panel so the panel sections do not scratch it. In the illustrated embodiment, the attachment points for the buckles are in proximity to the latching assemblies. By securing the

panels upright, they will not pivot back and forth, either falling towards and hitting the truck cab, or falling backwards back on top of the bed.

(83) A detail perspective view of a portion of cover **10** attached to bed **4** with side wall **6** is shown in FIG. **31**. Here panel sections **12**, **14**, and **16** are folded and raised upright vertically. They are also fitted in channel **270** of channel bracket **268**. A securement bracket **272**, part of securement system **24**, is attached to the underside of panel section **14** in proximity of latch **46** and pinch latch assembly **38**. In the illustrated embodiment, it fastens to panel section **14** using the same fasteners that secure latch guide **72** (see FIG. **7**) to panel section **14**. Another view of securement bracket **272** is shown in FIG. **11**. One end of buckle strap **278** is affixed to securement bracket **272** at **273**. In an illustrative embodiment the same fastener that attaches bracket **272** to panel section **214** may also attach strap **278** to bracket **272**. Buckle **280** attached to strap **272** inserts into buckle receptacle **274** opposite **273**. When buckle **280** is not needed it can be snapped into buckle receptacle **276** for storage (see, also, FIG. **33**).

(84) A side view of the portion of cover **10** is shown in FIG. **32**. This view shows panel sections **12**, **14**, and **16** positioned substantially vertically with sections **12** and **14** fitted in channel **270** of channel bracket **268** and secured into place via buckle strap **278** attached to receptacle **274** of buckle **280**. This view also depicts how channel bracket **268** keeps panel sections **12**, **14**, and **16** off of base panel section **18** so as to not mar the same. In addition to securing the panels in the fore and aft directions, the buckle assembly also helps secure the panel sections in the vertical direction so they do not bounce out of channel **270**.

(85) The perspective view of base panel section **18** is shown in FIG. **33**. This view depicts how channel bracket **268** is attached thereto. It is clear from these views how the width **286** of channel **270** is sized sufficient to hold panel sections **12** and **14**. It is appreciated that channel **270** may be sized to hold more or less panel sections as desired.

(86) As shown in FIG. **34**, when the panels **12**, **14**, and **16** are in a folded but horizontal position, affixing buckle **280** into receptacle **274**, helps secure the panels. In this configuration the panels will not unfold due to wind while the truck is moving.

(87) The figures and descriptions provided herein may have been simplified to illustrate aspects that are relevant for a clear understanding of the herein described devices, systems, and methods, while eliminating, for the purpose of clarity, other aspects that may be found in typical devices, systems, and methods. Those of ordinary skill may recognize that other elements and/or operations may be desirable and/or necessary to implement the devices, systems, and methods described herein. Because such elements and operations are well known in the art, and because they do not facilitate a better understanding of the present disclosure, a discussion of such elements and operations may not be provided herein. However, the present disclosure is deemed to inherently include all such elements, variations, and modifications to the described aspects that would be known to those of ordinary skill in the art.

(88) Although certain embodiments have been described and illustrated in exemplary forms with a certain degree of particularity, it is noted that the description and illustrations have been made by way of example only. Numerous changes in the details of construction, combination, and arrangement of parts and operations may be made. Accordingly, such changes are intended to be included within the scope of the disclosure, the protected scope of which is defined by the claims.

Claims

1. A tonneau cover for use over a truck bed of a pickup truck, the tonneau cover comprising: at least one panel section; a first latching assembly coupled to the at least one panel section; wherein the first latching assembly includes a first pinch latch assembly and a second pinch latch assembly; wherein the first pinch latch assembly includes a latch handle portion and an inner pinch handle portion; wherein when a force is applied to the first pinch latch assembly it moves to an unlatched

condition; and a light assembly located in the inner pinch handle portion of the first pinch latch assembly.

2. The tonneau cover of claim 1, further comprising a second panel section pivotally attached to the at least one panel section, a second latching assembly coupled to the second panel section, and a second light assembly located on the second latching assembly.

3. The tonneau cover of claim 1, further comprising a cavity disposed in the inner pinch handle portion of the first pinch latch assembly wherein the light assembly is received in the cavity.

4. The tonneau cover of claim 2, further comprising a second cavity disposed in an inner pinch handle portion of the second latching assembly and the second light assembly is received in the second cavity.

5. The tonneau cover of claim 1, wherein the first latching assembly includes a cavity disposed therein, wherein the cavity receives the light assembly.

6. The tonneau cover of claim 2, wherein the second latching assembly includes a second cavity disposed therein, wherein the second cavity receives the second light assembly.

7. A tonneau cover for use over a truck bed of a pickup truck, the tonneau cover comprising: a cover configured to shroud at least a portion of the truck bed; a first latching assembly coupled to the cover; a second latching assembly located opposite the first latching assembly; wherein the first latching assembly includes first and second pinch handles; wherein the first pinch handle of the first latching assembly actuates the second latching assembly and the second pinch handle of the first latching assembly actuates the first latching assembly; and a light assembly accompanying the first latching assembly; wherein the light assembly is coupled to the first latching assembly adjacent the first pinch handle.

8. The tonneau cover of claim 7, wherein the light assembly is located on an underside of the cover with the first latching assembly.

9. The tonneau cover of claim 7, wherein the cover is composed of at least a first panel section and a second panel section.

10. The tonneau cover of claim 7, wherein the second latching assembly includes a second light assembly coupled to the second latching assembly.

11. The tonneau cover of claim 7, wherein the light assembly is battery operated.

12. The tonneau cover of claim 7, further comprising a cavity disposed in the first latching assembly wherein the light assembly is received in the cavity.

13. A tonneau cover for use over a truck bed of a pickup truck, the tonneau cover comprising: at least one panel section; a first latching assembly coupled to the at least one panel section; a second latching assembly located opposite the first latching assembly on an opposing side of the at least one panel; wherein the first latching assembly includes at least one handle extending from an underside of the at least one panel section; wherein the at least one handle is engageable on the underside of the at least one panel section to be slid laterally with respect to the second latching assembly to unlatch the at least one panel section; and a light assembly located on the first latching assembly adjacent the at least one handle.

14. The tonneau cover of claim 13, wherein the first latching assembly includes a cavity disposed therein, wherein the cavity receives the light assembly.
